

Emergence of Bangladesh

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HIS 103

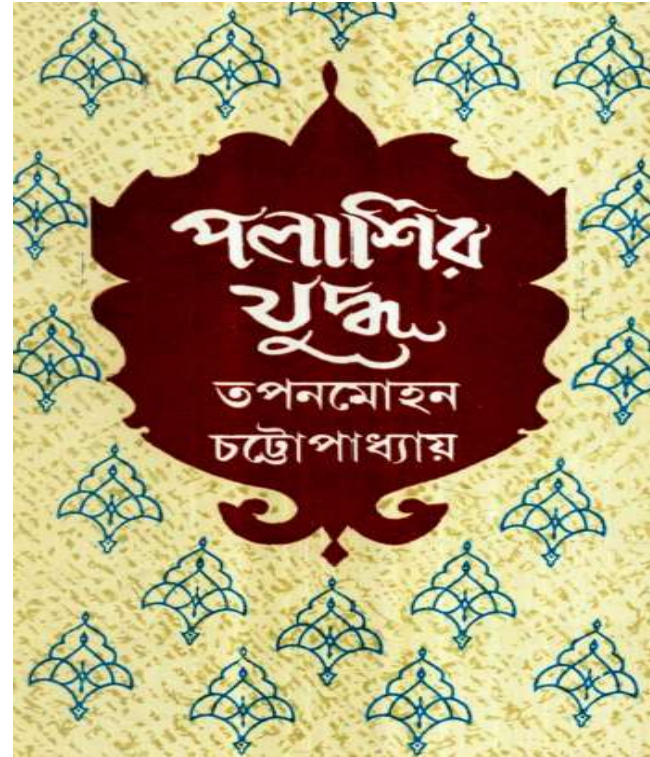
The Battle of Palashi for Drug Money & Colonial Takeover

Part-1

- The British East India Company (BEIC) was founded in 1600
- The Company received a “Loyal Charter” from Queen Elizabeth 1 to trade in Indices
- Initially, the focus of the Company was trade, not empire-building
- Competition and conflict with the Portuguese and Dutch companies
- Trading of basic commodities like salt, spices, tea, silk, opium
- In 1600, the British merchants founded the British East India Company to facilitate taking part in the flourishing opium trade. The victory of Plassey in 1757 provided the British East India Company with a stronger political hold over the opium trade in Patna and the surrounding poppy growing areas.

- In partnership with Dutch and the Portuguese, the English **maritime** trader initially came into the Indian Subcontinent.
- The British **naval exploration** goes back to King Henry the VIII from 1491 to 1547
- In 1613, the English merchant succeeded in securing permission from Emperor Jahangir to establish their **first business base** at Surat
- In 1639, the BEIC established its business base in Madras
- **In 1690, the BEIC secured trade facilities in Kolkata from the Nawab of Bengal against the payment of Rs. 1200/-per year**
- In 1717, the English got the **free trade access** in Bengal except for paying an annual sum of Rs. 3000/- payable to imperial treasury at Hoogly.





Nawab lost the battle, his life, and kingdom. Clive had around 3,000 troops and 10 small cannons against the Nawab's 62,000 troops and 50 large cannons.

Mir Jafar and two other generals, Rai Durlabh and Yar Lutuf Khan, with 30,000 infantry and 20,000 cavalry troops, abstained from fighting after a few hours when Clive's victory was imminent and inevitable. With 62,000 troops the Nawab should have won the battle before Mir Jafar and two other generals decided to remain inactive. The Nawab also had the support of a small French infantry and artillery. At the end of the day, Clive's and his officer's military genius, and his troops' advanced training, discipline, and valour, along with the Company's military organization, not Mir Jafar's (and Rai Durlabh's and Yar Lutuf Khan's) treachery sealed the fate of the Nawab.

The debacle came soon after the Nawab's troops and artillery had managed to push Clive and his men to a defensive position in the **mango grove of Plassey**. By noon, suddenly a heavy rainstorm engulfed Plassey and surrounding areas, turning the Nawab's artillery totally ineffective. While Clive's troops covered their guns and gunpowder with tarpaulins to protect them from the rainstorm – which lasted for a couple of hours – the Nawab's army had no such contingencies. Their guns being totally useless with rain-soaked gunpowder, the Nawab lost the battle.

Palashi, The Battle of was fought between Nawab [SIRAJUDDAULA](#) and the [EAST INDIA COMPANY](#) on 23 June 1757. It lasted for about eight hours and the nawab was defeated by the company because of the treachery of his leading general [MIR JAFAR](#). Palashi's political consequences were far-reaching and devastating and hence, though a mere skirmish, it has been magnified into a battle. It laid the foundation of the British rule in Bengal. For the English East India Company, Bengal was the springboard from which the British expanded their territorial domain and subsequently built up the empire which gradually engulfed most parts of India and ultimately many parts of Asia as well.

The Background The battle had a long background that could be traced from the beginning of the East India Company's settlement in Bengal in early 1650s. The Mughal rulers of Bengal allowed the East India Company to settle in Bengal and trade free of duty on payment of an annual sum of three thousand taka. Within a few years of their settlement at [HUGHLI](#) and [KASIMBAZAR](#) the company's trade began to expand rapidly both physically and in terms of capital investment. But their intrusion into the internal trade of Bengal became a cause of conflict between [SHAISTA KHAN](#), the Mughal subahdar, and the English in the last quarter of the 17th century. After Shaista Khan had left Bengal the English were allowed to settle in Calcutta, purchase the zamindari rights over the three villages of Kalikata, Govindapur and Sutanuti. They established a fort at Calcutta and named it [FORT WILLIAM](#).

The purchase of zamindari and the establishment of the Fort William proved highly profitable to the East India Company and the vested interest that was created in it led them to purchase more zamindari lands (38 villages) around Calcutta. Meanwhile the abuse of trade privileges progressively worsened their relations with the Bengal nawabs. The company's authority at Calcutta hardly paid any attention to the directives of the [COURT OF DIRECTORS](#) from London to stop this evil practice and the privileges of [DASTAK](#) was illegally extended from the import-export trade to cover also the internal trade. At the same time the servants of the company began to use the trade permit to cover their private trade.

The company in its attempt to secure more privileges approached the Mughal Emperor [FARRUKH SIYAR](#), who by a [FARMAN](#) (1717) granted it important privileges which included duty-free trade, establishment of a mint at Calcutta and right to purchase 38 villages on certain conditions. As other merchants had to pay duty at certain rates while the English and their partners traded duty-free, the local merchants were threatened to be eliminated from the internal trade. Nawab [MURSHID QULI KHAN](#) obstructed the implementation of the farman as he realised that in spite of the growing import-export trade of the company, it would escape with the annual payment of a meagre three thousand taka and the privileges would also deprive the government of its legitimate revenues from the internal trade as well as from the mint duties.

With the accession of Sirajuddaula in April 1756, the conflict between the nawab and the English company became almost inevitable as the young nawab, for the first time, protested vehemently against the unlawful activities of the company in Bengal. He had three main grievances against the British-the unauthorized fortifications of Fort William, illegal private trade and shameless abuse of dastaks by the company servants, and illegal shelter given to the nawab's erring subjects. The nawab asked the British to take measures to remove his grievances and sent several diplomatic missions to Calcutta for amicable settlement of the dispute. The nawab demanded the extradition of Krishna Das and asked the English to demolish the new fortifications and ordered to fill up the ditch, which surrounded the Calcutta Settlement. The English insulted nawab's special envoy, who carried his letter

The Conspiracy The tension of war continued as the English, disregarding the treaty, started hatching up a conspiracy with the disaffected courtiers of the nawab. There is no denial that a section of the influential members of the nawab's court at [MURSHIDABAD](#), who were dissatisfied with Sirajuddaula, was trying to hatch a conspiracy to oust the nawab. But the point to emphasise is that without the active involvement of the British, there would have been in all probability no Palashi 'revolution'. It was the British who were more anxious than the other conspirators to put their own scheme of overthrowing the nawab. The company servants and other merchant adventurers closely connected with the British trade in India - though not so much the Company Directors in London - did from time to time advocate, in no uncertain terms, the acquisition of territories in India. The private trades of the company servants was facing a severe crisis in the mid-18th century and in order to retrieve their private trade fortunes, they took recourse to 'sub-imperialism'.

In fact, the seeds of the Palashi conspiracy were sown in the 'Instructions' of the Fort George Council (13 October 1756) which recommended 'not mere retaking of Calcutta' and 'ample reparations', but urged 'to effect a junction with any powers in the province of Bengal that might be dissatisfied with the violence of the Nawab's government or that might have pretensions to the Nawabship'. The implication of the last portion of the recommendation is too obvious to be emphasised. Even Clive wrote before sailing from Madras that Sirajuddaula was a weak prince and that most of his courtiers were dissatisfied. It was on this resentment at the court of the nawab that the British played 'the nice important game', as Clive reflected later on, and precipitated the conspiracy leading to the Palashi coup.

Both Clive and Orme (who was the official historian of the English East India Company and was in Bengal in the early 1750s) were aware of Colonel Scott's plan, prepared in Calcutta in 1752, of the conquest of Bengal, which was then with the Fort George Council. Clive was greatly impressed by the wealth of Bengal on an earlier visit to Calcutta in the winter of 1749-50. The British private trade was facing a severe crisis in the late 1740s and early 1750s because of the sudden spurt in the French private trade and Asian maritime trade under the Armenian merchant Khwaja Wajid as is borne out by the shipping lists in the Dutch records. So the destruction of the French, which would prevent a Franco-Bengali alliance, and the deposition of the nawab who was threatening to stop the illegal private trade and misuse of dastaks - both essential for rescuing the battered private trade fortunes of the British - became the main target of the company servants' sub-imperialism.

বাংলার নবাব সিরাজউদ্দৌলাকে ছেঁড়া ময়লা কাপড় পরিয়ে, একটা ছাকরা গাড়িতে চড়িয়ে তাঁর নিজের রাজধানীতে বন্দী-অবস্থায় ফিরিয়ে নিয়ে আসা হ'ল। তখন দুপুর বেলা। মীর জাফর খেয়ে-দেয়ে ঘুমতে যাচ্ছেন। বন্দীকে নিয়ে তিনি যে কি করবেন তা স্থির করতে না পেরে, তাঁর উপযুক্ত পুত্র মীরনের হাতে সিরাজউদ্দৌলাকে সমর্পণ ক'রে দিয়ে ঘুমতে চ'লে গেলেন। যাবার সময় শুধু ব'লে গেলেন, বন্দীকে যেন খুব হ'শিয়ারিতে রাখা হয়।

মীরন তাঁর ইয়ারবর্গকে ডেকে বললেন, এই রকম এক দায়ি মাল সারাদিন ধ'রে হ'শিয়ার হ'য়ে হেফাজত করতে হ'লে গেছি আর কি? ১৮২

তার চেয়ে ওটাকে একেবারে খতম ক'রে ফেলাই তো ঢের বেশি বুদ্ধির কাজ।

কিন্তু কোনো আমীর-ওমরাও সিরাজের গায়ে হাত তুলতে রাজি হলেন না। তখন মহম্মদী বেগ ব'লে এক জহান্নামপ্রকৃতির লোক ঐ কাজ করতে স্বীকার গেল। সে যাবে না কেন? সিরাজউদ্দৌলার বাবাই তো তাকে অনাধ দেখে মাহুষ করেছিলেন। সিরাজের মা-ই তো ঘটা ক'রে তার বিয়ে দিইয়ে দিয়েছিলেন। রুতজ্জতার কাঁটা তো তখনো তার বুকে খচখচ করছে। সে-কাঁটা তোলবার এই তো সুযোগ। সে-ব্যক্তি সিরাজউদ্দৌলাকে খুন করতে চাইবে না তো আর কে চাইবে?

নবাব সিরাজউদ্দৌলা এই ছোটলোকের পায়ে প'ড়ে কাকুতি-মিনতি ক'রে প্রাণভিক্ষা চাইতে লাগলেন। কেঁদে বললেন, তিনি আর কিছুই চান না। শুধু, বহদুরে কোনো অজানা গ্রামে গিয়ে গোপনে এক সামান্য প্রজার মতন বাস করতে পারলেই তিনি চিরকৃতজ্ঞ থাকবেন। তাঁর অনুরোধ, এই কথাটা যেন মীর জাফরকে একবার জানানো হয়।

কিন্তু জানিয়ে কোনো ফল হ'ল না। নীচ লোক কি কখনো ক্ষমা করতে পারে? সে পারেন একমাত্র যিনি বীরপুরুষ। নীচ ব্যক্তির তো সর্বদাই নিকরুণা ভবন্তি। তাই তো নীচ লোকের কাছে প্রার্থী হওয়ার মতন এমন কদর্য জিনিস দুনিয়ায় আর কিছু নেই।

ফিরে এসে মহম্মদী বেগ সিরাজকে হাতমুখ ধুয়ে কল্মা পড়বার সময়টুকু পর্যন্ত দিল না। সাধারণ চোর-ছাঁচোড়ের মতন পিটিয়ে-পিটিয়ে ঠেঙিয়ে-ঠেঙিয়ে সিরাজকে খুন ক'রে ফেলল। ২রা জুলাই ১৭৫৭। নিয়তির কী নিদারুণ খেলা!

এইখানেই কথাটা শেষ করতে পারলেই ভালো হ'ত। কিন্তু পরমেশ্বরের করুণার নাম ক'রে যারা মাহুষ খুন করে, তাদের নির্দয়তার তো আর সীমা-পরিসীমা থাকে না। তাই আরো-একটু বলতে হচ্ছে।

পরদিন সকালে এক হাতির পিঠে সিরাজের মৃতদেহ চড়িয়ে দিয়ে সমস্ত শহরটা ধ'রে সেই হাতিটাকে রাস্তায়-রাস্তায় ঘোরানো হ'ল। সকলেই যেন প্রত্যয় যায়, নবাব সিরাজউদ্দৌলা আর ইহজগতে নেই।

Regulating Act, 1773:

- BEIC's corruption and nepotism
- Financial crisis
- Famine of 1770 (ছিয়াত্তরের মন্বন্তর)
- Robert Clive's **dual rule** (the company had Diwani rights in Bengal while the Nawab had Nizamat rights (judicial and policing rights) as secured from the Mughal Emperor)
- BEIC's victory and the defeat of Mir Kashim in the Battle of **Buxer of 1764**

The Regulating Act of 1773:

The regulating Act of 1773 was passed by the British Parliament **to control** the territories of the East India Company majorly in Bengal. This act was passed due to the misgovernment by the British East India government that introduced a situation of bankruptcy and the government had to interfere with the affairs of the Company.

Main Provisions of the Regulating Act of 1773:

- This act permitted the company to retain its territorial possessions in India but sought to regulate the activities and functioning of the company.
- The act provided for the appointment of a **Governor-General** along with four Councillors in the Presidency of Fort William (Calcutta), jointly called the **Governor-General in Council**. **Warren Hastings** was appointed as the Governor-General.
- **The company directors were elected for a period of five years and one-fourth of them were to retire every year. Also, they could not be re-elected.**
- A supreme court was established in Calcutta. Judges were to come from England.

Part-2

MUGHAL DRUG POLICY

Abul Fazl, the historian of Akbar's time and the writer of the *Akbarnamah* claimed that poppy was one of the most valuable crops and an **important source of revenue** during the time of Akbar. Between 1653 and 1708, opium was one of the **exportable commodities** of the Mughal kingdom. Given the varied information, it is difficult to arrive at a conclusion that the Mughals had any monopoly in the opium trade .

- Poppy cultivation

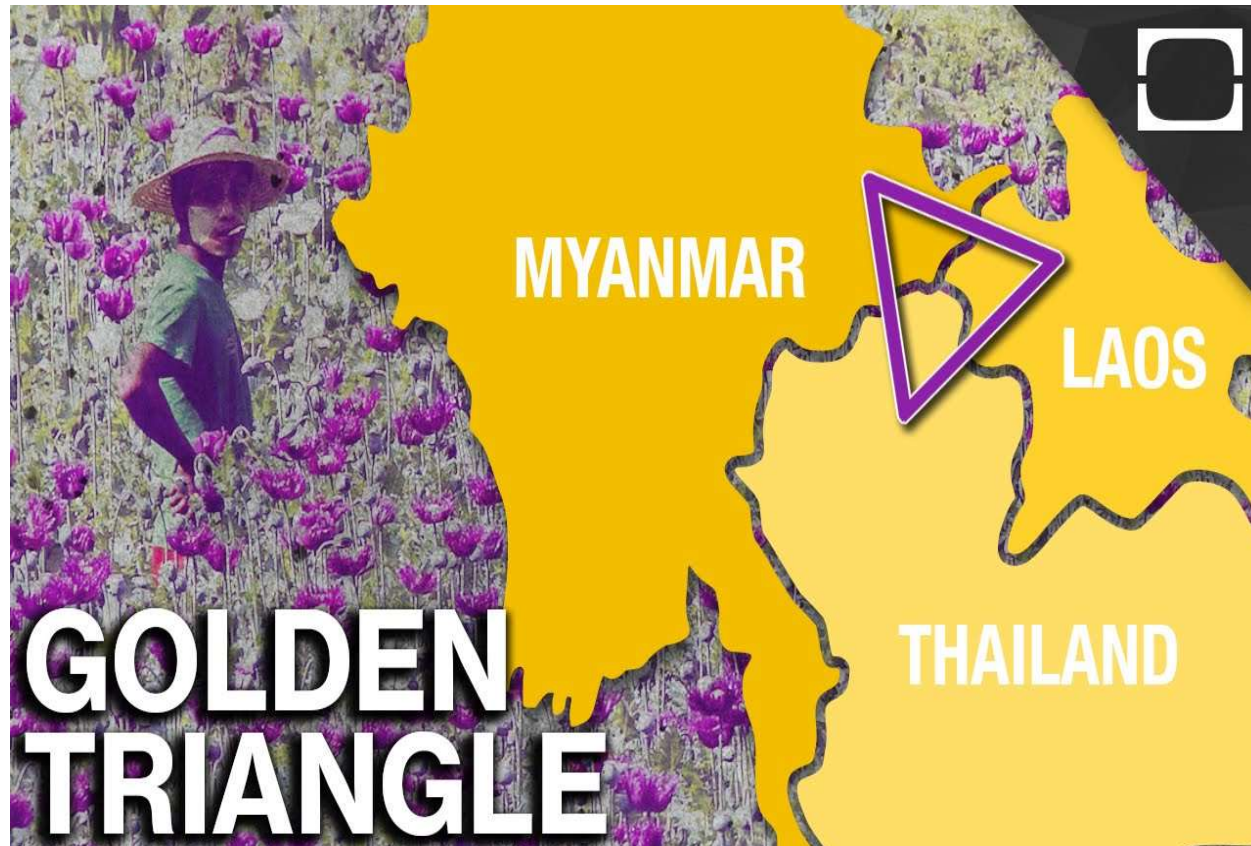


British colonial drug policy

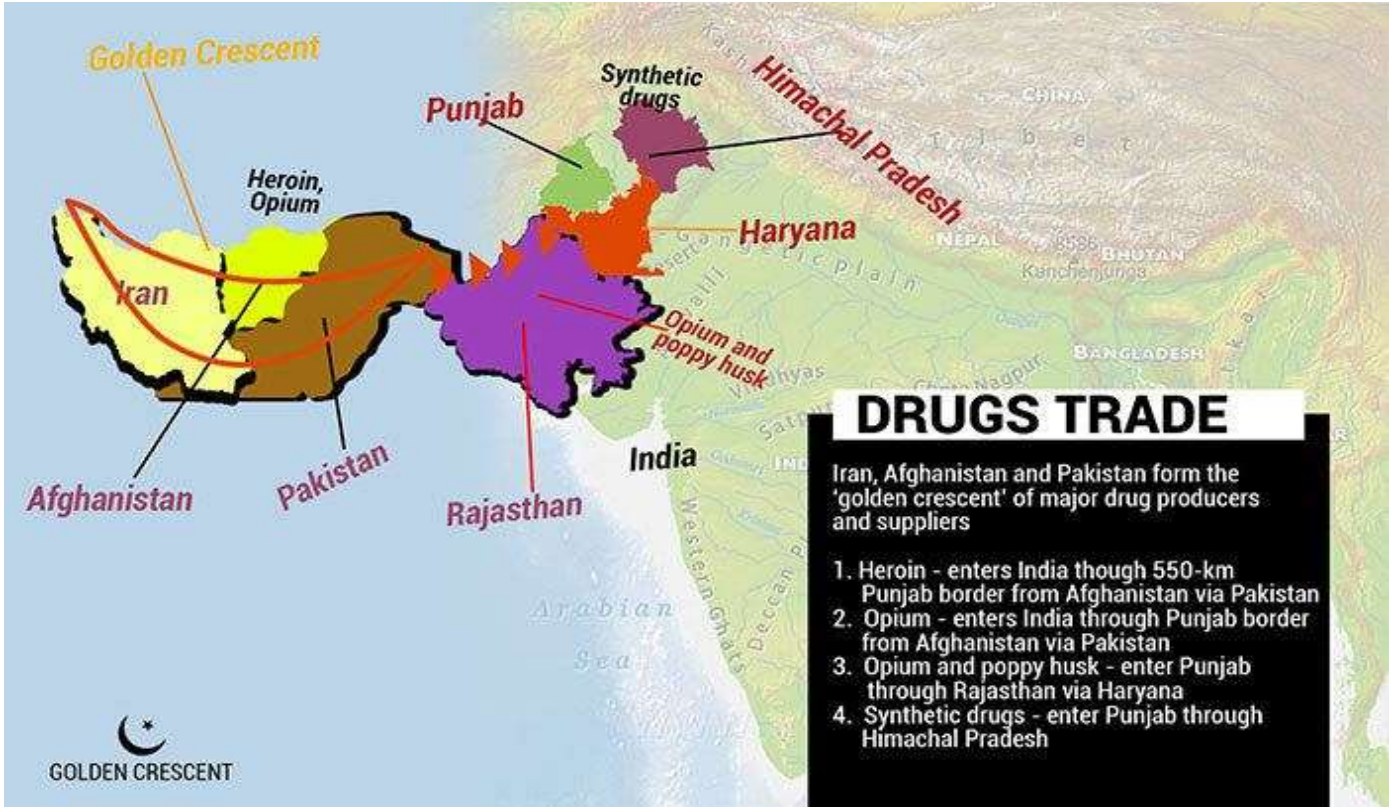
1. At the time of growth and development of the opium monopoly in Bengal from 1773 to 1856, the economic condition of the poppy farmers (*ryots*) had deteriorated and tension had erupted between the local *zamindars* (landlords) and the colonial authorities. This conflict aided in the eventual uprising of 1857, also known as the Indian 'Sepoy Mutiny'. In an attempt to further control the private cultivation of opium poppies and the free trade in opium, the government adopted the Opium Act of 1857 and the Opium Act of 1878.
2. The colonial drug laws applied a **double standard**, as they allowed the imperial authorities to appropriate revenue from **the state-run opium monopoly**, while pushing the private traders to become involved in the contraband trade.
3. The Indian opium trade flourished until the late nineteenth century, when China emerged as a major market for the supply of opium from India

Thus, the history of the drug trade in Asia has **a complex political background with numerous cross-regional connections.**

Golden Triangle

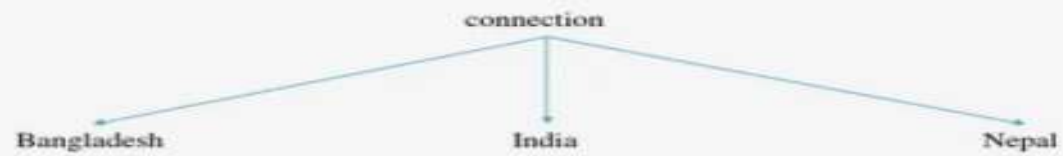


Golden Crescent



Golden wedge

Golden Wedge



Bengal opium traffic 1773-1856

- The Arab physicians, who had learnt the **medicinal application of opium** (*Papaver Somniferum*) from the Greeks, came in contact with India from the eighth century AD.

In collaboration with Dutch, Portuguese and then the English trading companies, a group of private traders evolved in sporadic poppy cultivation in some parts of India in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries.

With the establishment of political rule, the British East India Company **eventually expelled** all other parties from the opium trade and came in conflict with the local zamindars that attempted to resist the large scale **conversion of fertile land into poppy cultivation**. This rift eventually contributed to the great **uprising of 1857** in the **poppy growing areas**

To organize the opium enterprise, the government of the East India Company in 1763 established the so-called 'Gentlemen's monopoly' run by the Patna Council. It consisted of Company officials, who entered the business directly and distributed money through Indian agents (*gumastas*) amongst farmers to grow opium poppies. The employees received their salaries from the profits they made individually in the opium monopoly.

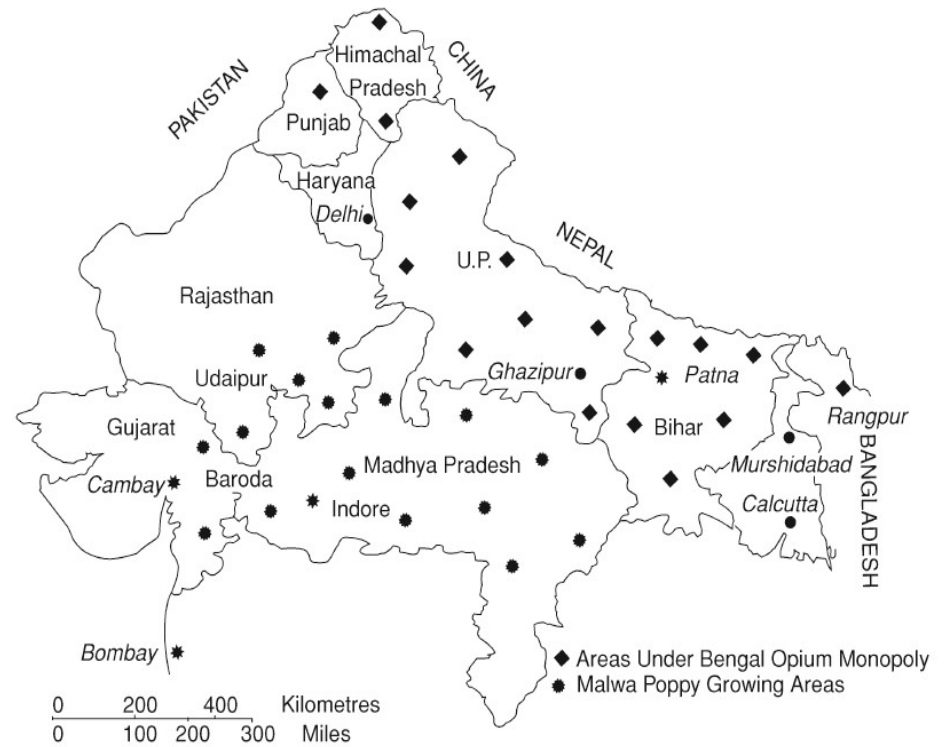
Business consortium in opium:

In an attempt to establish a business consortium in opium, the East India authorities in 1765 allowed other European companies to participate in a joint venture under one general agent. **Malpractice and corruption of officials** affected this system, when the respective companies started to 'trade clandestinely on their own account in the drug.

INCREASE OF POPPY LAND CULTIVATION:

Under the joint venture, the land under poppy cultivation was increased from **283,000 hectares in 1765-6, to 303,500 hectares** in the following year. **This large-scale conversion of paddy fields into poppy cultivation contributed to a famine in Bengal in 1770.** This famine caused the **death of 10 million** people in an area that had been traditionally known as the 'Golden Bengal' due to its natural resources.

Poppy Growing Areas



Map 1 India: traditional poppy growing areas (1997 boundary)

Table 1.1 *Bengal government opium monopoly, 1844–55*

<i>Year</i>	<i>Total exports (in metric tons)</i>	<i>Total receipts (in million Rs)</i>
1845–6	1572	26.68
1846–7	1577	27.80
1847–8	2230	27.26
1848–9	2612	35.47
1849–50	2500	35.72
1850–1	2334	32.62
1851–2	2213	37.74
1852–3	2557	38.73
1853–4	3144	37.22
1854–5	3241	37.11

Source: ‘Returns Relating to the Growth, &c; of Opium’, British Parliamentary Papers, *East India (Opium)*, 1857, Session 1 (60), volume 11, p. 124.

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Questions and Answers